

The Contemporary World - Module 4 Reviewer

The Global Interstate System

Overview

The world is divided into states that recognize each other as sovereign. This module explains how that system emerged and how globalization is testing it.

Learning Outcomes

- Define the interstate system and the principle of sovereignty.
- Explain the significance of the Peace of Westphalia (1648).
- Discuss how globalization challenges the nation-state.
- Distinguish hegemony from other forms of power.

The Interstate System

The interstate system is the network of relations among sovereign states, each claiming authority over a territory and its people. It is the political backbone of the modern world order.

- States as the main actors
- Recognition of borders and sovereignty
- Diplomacy, alliances, and conflict

The Westphalian Order

The treaties of 1648 ended the Thirty Years' War in Europe and are commonly credited with establishing the idea that each state is supreme within its own territory and should not interfere in the affairs of others.

- Territorial sovereignty
- Non-intervention
- Balance of power

Sovereignty and the State

Sovereignty has an internal side (supreme authority at home) and an external side (independence from outside control). Globalization strains both: capital flows, migration, and global rules limit what states can do alone.

- Internal and external sovereignty
- Pooling sovereignty (EU, ASEAN)
- Debates on humanitarian intervention

Nation-States and Globalization

Some argue globalization is eroding the nation-state; others argue states remain powerful and have adapted, using regulation, borders, and industrial policy. The Philippine state, for example, manages labor migration and trade policy in a global setting.

- "Hyperglobalist" vs. "skeptic" positions
- States as gatekeepers and regulators
- Case: labor export policy

Global Powers and Hegemony

Hegemony is leadership or dominance by one state within the system. Britain in the 19th century and the United States after 1945 are classic examples. Today, debates focus on the rise of China and a more multipolar order.

- Hegemon: military, economic, and cultural leadership
- World-systems view: core, semi-periphery, periphery
- Unipolar vs. multipolar world

Review Questions

1. Explain: The Interstate System.
2. Explain: The Westphalian Order.
3. Explain: Sovereignty and the State.
4. Explain: Nation-States and Globalization.
5. Explain: Global Powers and Hegemony.